

The Meaning of Life Across Scholarly Disciplines

Project Narrative

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<https://github.com/rahmanshanq/tmol>

Motivation

The question of how to live a meaningful life gets asked in philosophy departments, psychology labs, Sufi lodges, Buddhist monasteries, Confucian academies, Indigenous communities. Different centuries, different vocabularies. Same underlying problem. What struck me early is how little these traditions talk to each other. A psychologist measuring "meaning in life" with Ed Diener's satisfaction scales has almost certainly never read al-Ghazali's *Kimiya al-Sa'ada*. A philosopher working on eudaimonia may have no idea that *ikigai* has generated its own body of peer-reviewed research in Japan. The silos run deep.

I wanted to see those silos. Map them. Find out whether any bridges exist that the individual literatures don't acknowledge.

Process

Term Curation

Everything depended on the search terms. Using only English-language psychology jargon would produce a psychology-heavy dataset and then generate a conclusion that psychology dominates the conversation. Circular. So I spent real time building a term list that could cut across traditions without pre-imposing structure on what it found.

Manual brainstorming produced the first round. *Eudaimonia*, *phronesis*, *flourishing* from the Greek tradition. *Saada*, *falah*, *maqasid al-shariah* from Islamic thought. *Moksha*, *dharma*, *purushartha* from Hindu philosophy. *Ikigai* from Japan. *Ubuntu* from Africa. *Buen vivir* from the Andes. About 90 terms came out of that first pass.

Then I ran two rounds of vector-space discovery using the all-MiniLM-L6-v2 sentence-transformer. Embed the existing terms, pull abstracts and keywords from OpenAlex for related queries, embed those, measure which new terms cluster nearest to my seed list. The first round caught *self-determination theory*, *narrative identity*, *terror management theory*. Concepts I hadn't thought to include. The second round surfaced more niche vocabulary like *bodhisattva*, *hermeneutics*, *dialogical self*.

After both rounds I reviewed for structural gaps. Anthropology was almost entirely missing, which was a problem since it's arguably the discipline most engaged with cross-cultural understandings of well-being. Subjectivity and phenomenological vocabulary were thin. I'd transliterated Arabic terms (*saada*, *falah*, *tawakkul*) but left Chinese, Sanskrit, Japanese, Korean, and Hebrew terms in their original scripts, which OpenAlex can't search. Fixed all of these.

One decision shaped everything after it. I kept the term list flat. No pre-clustering by tradition. Whether *eudaimonia* belongs to philosophy or psychology is exactly the kind of question the dashboard should answer from the data, and imposing that structure beforehand would have compromised the analysis. The final list had 245 terms across 16 traditions, with a documented count per tradition so the coverage imbalance stayed visible.

Data Collection

I queried the OpenAlex API for all 245 terms, pulling up to 500 works per term. Each work came with title, abstract, publication year, journal name, and author institutional affiliations. The collection ran in batches of 50 to respect rate limits. After deduplicating by work ID the dataset held 129,672 unique scholarly works. About 77% had abstracts.

Building the Classifier

This turned out to be the most consequential decision in the project. OpenAlex assigns every paper a field classification based on journal metadata and citation patterns. Testing it against my data revealed serious problems. Papers about Aristotle's eudaimonia were tagged as Social Psychology. Papers on *maqasid al-shariah* ended up under

Accounting. One paper on ubuntu philosophy got classified as Computer Science. The classifier had confused the African philosophical concept with the Linux operating system.

So I built my own. Sixteen descriptions, one per tradition, each packed with the names, concepts, and vocabulary that define how that tradition thinks about the good life. The Islamic Thought description references al-Ghazali, Ibn Sina, maqasid, tazkiyat al-nafs, falah. The Buddhist one covers the Four Noble Truths, the Eightfold Path, dukkha, nirvana, metta, karuna. I embedded these using sentence-transformers and compared each paper's title and abstract (70% weight) plus journal name (30%) against all 16 anchors via cosine similarity. Papers where two traditions scored within 92% of each other got both labels. When the journal name was unreliable, the system dropped it and classified on content alone.

Validation against known test cases showed the classifier significantly outperformed OpenAlex on non-Western categories. Mindfulness papers, which legitimately straddle Buddhist Thought and Psychology, received dual labels when scores were close enough. That felt right.

Visualizations

The Network Graph

The centerpiece. A force-directed constellation where each node is a scholarly tradition and each edge represents papers bridging two traditions. I chose a network because the core question is relational. A bar chart can show that psychology produces more papers than anyone else. It can't show that Buddhist and Hindu thought share 3,063 works between them, or that Anthropology reaches Indigenous traditions in ways no other discipline does.

Traditions render as glowing nodes against a dark background, sized by publication volume. Edges glow gold on selection. Hovering any node surfaces its top connections and paper count. Clicking loads a panel of actual papers with links to OpenAlex. Clicking a connection bar narrows the panel to papers specifically bridging those two traditions. The heatmap alongside shows the full matrix of connection strengths.

The Animated Bar Chart Race

An animated chart that plays through 1960 to 2025, showing traditions accumulate scholarship year by year. In the early decades, Western Philosophy and Christian Theology led. By the late 1990s, Psychology overtook everything, accelerating sharply after Martin Seligman's 1998 APA presidential address launched the positive psychology movement. A static chart can state that fact. The animation makes it feel like something that actually happened. A slider lets users scrub to any specific year.

I paired the race with a streamgraph on the same page. The streamgraph renders the same data as flowing layers, each tradition's width representing annual output. Better for volume trends. The race is better for ranking shifts. Together they give two angles on the temporal story.

The Geographic Choropleth with Time Slider

A world map color-coded by research volume, with a yearly slider running 1960 to 2025. Dragging it forward shows countries entering the conversation over time. Indonesia lights up as Islamic studies grow. India brightens with Hindu scholarship. The map fills gradually from a handful of Anglophone countries toward something more global.

A second choropleth on the same page shows the dominant tradition per country. Psychology dominates the Anglosphere. Islamic Thought dominates Southeast Asia and the Middle East. Hindu Thought concentrates in South Asia. The geographic clustering is striking, and the volume map alone wouldn't capture it.

Key Findings

Psychology leads with about 15,500 works. Under OpenAlex's classifier that dominance would look even more extreme, because papers about eudaimonia and ikigai get absorbed into psychological categories. Under the custom classifier the picture changes. Existentialism and Phenomenology accounts for 11,191 works. Hindu Thought for 10,744. Islamic Thought for 9,126. The conversation is substantially more pluralistic than standard bibliometric tools suggest.

The strongest bridge in the dataset runs between Buddhist and Hindu thought at 3,063 shared works. Stronger than anything within the Western academy. Anthropology functions as the most consistent bridge discipline. And Existentialism turned out to be the unexpected connective tissue, linking to almost every other tradition in the network. Frankl, Heidegger, Buber, the phenomenological tradition generally. They connect to everything.

33.1% of papers received dual-tradition labels. A third of the scholarship lives at intersections. Two-thirds stays inside disciplinary walls. Geographically, the United States produces more on this topic than the next five countries combined.

Outlook

Going multilingual would be the most impactful extension. Adding Arabic, Chinese, Sanskrit, Japanese, and Korean search terms and querying databases that index non-English scholarship would transform this into something closer to the actual global conversation. A larger model fine-tuned on hand-labeled data would improve classification. Tracing actual citation links (OpenAlex provides these) would sharpen the network. And deploying it publicly with scheduled data updates would make it a living resource rather than a finished project.

AI Usage

I used Claude (Anthropic) throughout. It wrote the vector-discovery scripts, the API collection code, the classifier, the Dash dashboard, and drafted this writeup. I directed the research question, made the methodological calls (flat term list, custom classifier, tradition selection), caught structural gaps, ran the classifier locally, tested every component, and revised all written output.